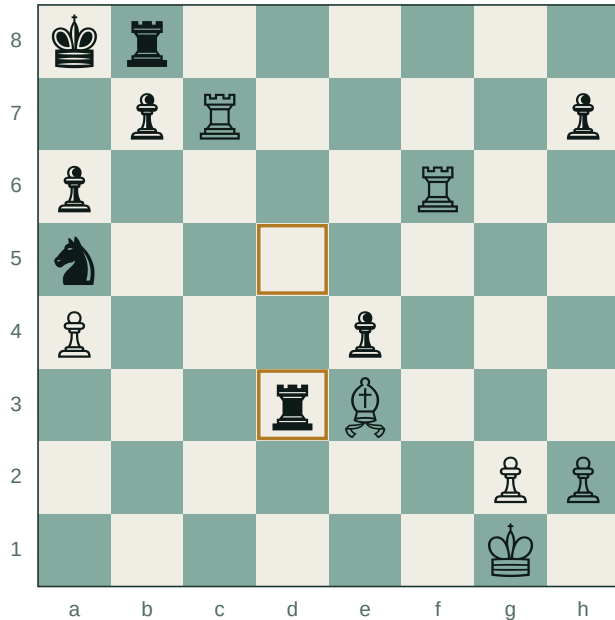


Mate in two: White, move 39

Mate in two

White to move



Previous move: 38...Rd3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

39. Rxa6+ bxa6 40. Ra7#

39.Rxa6+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From a6 it attacks king on a8 and knight on a5. Recorded reply: **39...bxa6**.

40.Ra7# Mate: rook on a7 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on a8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on a7. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The displayed line is one recorded defense. Test other legal replies instead of assuming the defender must copy it.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A mating combination must survive the defender's reply. The first move should force a position in which a second move ends the game against every defense.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the likely mating square and the defender that prevents it. Calculate the forcing move that removes that resource.

The defending king is on a8. Geometrically undefended: knight on a5. Check for tactical protection.